

TAGUS VALLEY

The great natural artery of Iberia

The principal river of Spain and Portugal passes through some of the most biodiverse landscapes in Europe, with a mixture of both European and North African plants and animals. The Tagus river begins its course in Spain's forested Alto Tajo Natural Park, cutting a series of dramatic limestone gorges. It winds past cereal fields, olive groves, and world-renowned vineyards and cork oak forests, and powers more than 60 hydroelectric dams. Then it cleaves its way through the spectacular canyons of the Monfragüe National Park, where birds of prey including the Iberian imperial eagle, black and griffon vultures, and European eagle owls are found.

Protected river

The river and its adjacent habitats remain protected as it passes into Portugal within the boundaries of the International Tagus Natural Park, which was created

in 2000. Roughly 60 miles (100km) from the sea, the valley opens out onto a broad floodplain, and emerges into one of the largest and most important wetlands in Europe. Here, extensive saltmarsh and creeks provide prime habitats for birds including the greater flamingo, little egret, purple heron, booted eagle, and Montagu's harrier. They also provide a major stopover point for birds migrating between Europe and Africa.

Commercial forestry is banned in most of the national parks that the river passes through, and work to eradicate introduced trees in Monfragüe National Park, especially eucalyptus, is ongoing.



REPTILE REFUGE
The Mediterranean pond turtle is widely threatened by wetland drainage and pollution. It is protected under national and European law, and the Tagus Valley is considered an important stronghold for the species.

Longest river in Iberia at more than 620 miles (1,000 km)

DECLINING AMPHIBIAN
The European tree frog favors the open-canopied forests and meadows that flank sections of the Tagus. It uses pools and swamps to breed and so is affected by drainage and water pollution. Another factor in its decline is collection for the pet trade.



EUROPEAN TREE FROG

ENDEMIC EAGLE

The Iberian imperial eagle population fell to just 30 pairs in the 1970s as a result of habitat loss and collisions with powerlines. Thousands of pylons have since been modified and the population now numbers more than 600 adult birds.



IMPERIAL EAGLE

45% of Tagus fish species

